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From the editor-in-chief

Trust Margaret Thatcher to understand and explain true power. The Iron Lady once said, "Being powerful is like being a lady. If you have to tell people you are, you aren't." She would know. Our job as journalists, though, is to keep track of the powerful. To trace them, identify them, follow them and once every year single them out as belonging to that elusive yet fundamental entity known as the Establishment.

These are people who belong neither to the Government nor do they occupy positions where they can wield official power. They are important because of what they do and influential because of their impact on the wider public. They could be businessmen, scientists, actors, athletes, environmentalists, academicians, lawyers, and even out of power politicians. When they move, all of India takes notice. When they speak, all of us listen.

In order to identify who makes up India's establishment, we began our annual High & Mighty list eight years ago. It has always made the news, flattered some, rankled many but it has always been flexible and changed with the times. This year there are nine new entrants—nearly 20 per cent, to use a statistical analysis—in the Power List. It has to be said that only 16 in our list of 50 High & Mighty have stayed on the list since the first in 2003. Once again Ratan Tata and the Ambani brothers hold the same spots as last year. The average age, interestingly, has dropped from 59 in 2003 to 54 in the last two years.

We have always believed in a ranking system but in the nature of things it is subjective. It is based on a consensus reached after discussions between the senior editors of the magazine. We deliberate on the rank as much as the names.

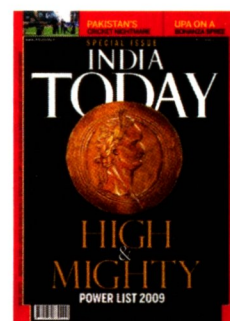
This makes the list dynamic which reflects how people have done in the year. It is why Aamir Khan and Sachin Tendulkar have leap-frogged from where they were the year before—in their completely different fields, they both have had an astonishing 12 months. Businessmen are back, recovering from a reeling economy, 23 featuring in our top 50.

Every year, we add a new dimension to our Power List. If it was including a top 10 list of the Official High & Mighty in 2006, then last year we introduced a list of top 20 overseas Indians.

This year we introduce you to The Advisers. This is made of the 10 people in the country who are at the core of major policy decisions taken by the Government. These are people who are mostly unseen. Their power lies in how they use their minds to conceive changes that often impact the lives of millions. For example, someone like Sam Pitroda, who features high on the list, was known as Rajiv Gandhi's Telecom Czar and responsible for India's telecom industry leaping from the middle ages to the modern world in the 1980s. The Advisers find their way into government and need not always be cadre bureaucrats. They are actually a reflection of how the country's elected leaders are thinking.

Every year when the INDIA TODAY High & Mighty List is about to be released, we are besieged by one set of people who want to know who's in and who's out. And proving Maggie Thatcher right, the people who don't bother are the ones usually high up on the list.

(Aroon Purie)



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HIGH & MIGHTY COVER



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